



EDO PERIOD

JAPANESE ARTS FLOURISHED UNDER THE TOKUGAWA SHOGUNS' RULE

The Edo period (1603–1868) was one of peace. The merchant class grew wealthier and better educated, and began to enjoy arts that were previously the preserve of the landowning elites and the samurai warrior class.

Japanese craftsmen were inspired by the culture of *ukiyo* (Floating World), itself inspired by the Buddhist idea that all is illusion. In Edo Japan *ukiyo* became associated with fleeting pleasures—from dallying with courtesans to attending kabuki dance dramas. Craftsmen strove for an esthetic of otherworldly elegance. Surrounded by beauty, their clients set about their pursuits, from writing to prayer, as though they too were part of the illusory Floating World.

